In my first year at Shardashram, I played fifty five practice matches during the summer break of sixty days. My summer sessions used to start at 7.30 am and end at 4.30 pm. My evening session would start at 5 pm after only a thirty-minute break. During the break, Sir would often give me some money to go and have a *vadapav* (a popular Mumbai fast food).



Between 5 pm and 7 pm I'd have five more net sessions. Towards the last 15 minutes, Sir would place a one rupee coin on top of the stumps and if I managed to avoid getting out, the coin was mine. In this session every bowler in the camp would come and bowl to me, with some sixty to seventy boys fielding. It meant I had to hit every ball along the ground to survive those intense fifteen minutes. Winning the one–rupee coin used to give me immense satisfaction and taught me how to concentrate even when physically drained. At the end of it all., Sir would tell me to run two full circuits of Shivaji Park with my pads and gloves on. That was the last part of my training and I'd be completely exhausted by the end of it all. It was a routine I would repeat right through my summer holidays and it helped me to build up physical and mental stamina.

- What did Sachin do during the thirty minute break?
- What is the intense 'fifteen minutes' mentioned ?

Occasionally, my father came to take me home and I would always ask him to treat me to a special fruit cocktail at a juice centre near the club. While this regular demand was a little unreasonable, because at the time I did not realize that my parents also had to take care of the needs of my brothers and sister, my father would invariably end up giving me what I wanted, just to see me happy. On other days, when I made my way home from Shivaji Park on my own, I'd often fall asleep on the bus – if I managed to sit down. Anyone who has been on a Mumbai bus at peak hours will know just how difficult it is to get a seat. On days when I wasn't so lucky, it was still a challenge just to stand with the kitbag, because the bus conductors would inevitably complain about me taking up the space of another passenger. It could be embarrassing because the conductors were often rude and would sometimes ask me to buy two tickets. I didn't have the money for a second ticket and I had to learn to take these remarks in my stride. Dirty clothes often added to the embarrassment. With time, I evolved a way of wrapping the kitbag around me. Just as the helmet and

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